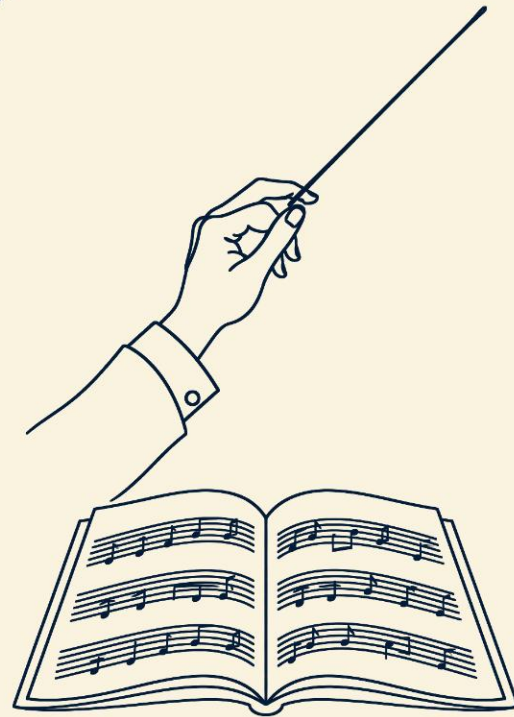


HOLLYWOOD HAS A FRENCH ACCENT

The Closed Circle of French Composers Who Keep Winning Oscars



A lone rider on a camel. A horizon of sand. Then the strings rise and the whole cinema sits up.



Lawrence of Arabia, 1962. Written in six weeks by a Frenchman from Lyon who had never seen a desert.

The Music You Already Know

You know the melody. You have never known the face.

Maurice Jarre won three Oscars. Almost no American could pick him out of a crowd.

For sixty years a small circle of French composers has written the sound of American cinema — quietly.

A Journey Through a Music with No Face



Introduction to the Subject and Guiding Thread

The mystery.

Film music is the only art in cinema whose author is invisible. The actor has a face, the director a name.

The circle.

Jarre, Legrand, Lai, Delerue, Yared, Bource, Desplat. Seven Frenchmen, more than a dozen Oscars for music, from 1962 to the present day.

The thread.

A singular sensibility — melody first, melancholy allowed, elegance over spectacle — that Hollywood could not produce and therefore imported.

Tonight we put faces to the melodies — and ask why the Academy keeps falling for the French ear.

PART 1

THE TWO MASTERS

*Maurice Jarre and Michel Legrand — Parallel
Paths to the Oscars*



The Four Founding Dates

The arc of a French Hollywood in four milestones.

1962

Lawrence of Arabia. Maurice Jarre's first Oscar.

1968

The Windmills of Your Mind. Michel Legrand's first Oscar.

2014

The Grand Budapest Hotel. Alexandre Desplat's first Oscar.

2018

The Shape of Water. Desplat's second. The circle still closed.

Half a century of statuettes — and the same accent on the acceptance speeches.

Maurice Jarre — The Architect of Epics

Lyon, 1924 — Los Angeles, 2009

The late starter.

He studies percussion at the Conservatoire, writes for the theatre of Jean Vilar, scores French films of the 1950s — and is unknown abroad at thirty-seven.

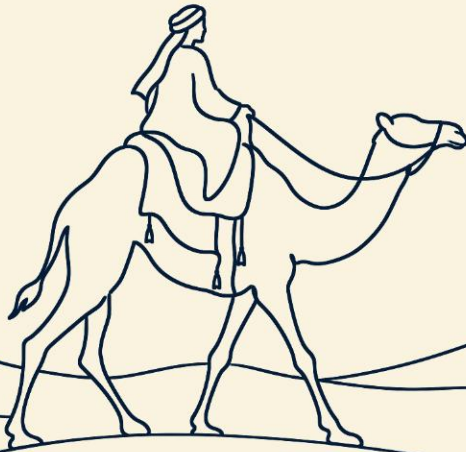
The six weeks.

Sam Spiegel's plan for Lawrence of Arabia collapses: William Walton and Aram Khachaturian fall away. Jarre writes the entire score in six weeks.

The Lean trilogy.

Doctor Zhivago (1965), with Lara's Theme on balalaikas, and A Passage to India (1984). Three David Lean films, three Oscars.

Hollywood asked for the sound of the horizon. A man from Lyon gave it one.





Michel Legrand — The Jazzman Who Sang in Colour

Paris, 1932. A prodigy at the Conservatoire under Nadia Boulanger; a jazz arranger by twenty; Legrand Jazz with Miles Davis in 1958.

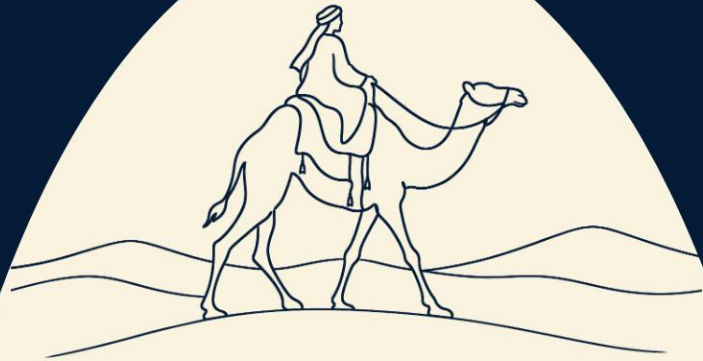
Demy. Les Parapluies de Cherbourg (1964): every line of dialogue sung. Les Demoiselles de Rochefort (1967).

The three Oscars. The Windmills of Your Mind (The Thomas Crown Affair, 1968), Summer of '42 (1971), Yentl (1983). More than two hundred film scores.

Jarre painted landscapes. Legrand wrote the ache inside the room. Hollywood wanted both.

Parallel Paths

Jarre and Legrand — Two Ways to Conquer America



Maurice Jarre

Moves to Los Angeles in 1962. Lean, Hitchcock, Weir. Three Oscars.



Michel Legrand

Never leaves Paris for long. Demy, Streisand, Dessay. Three Oscars.

Two opposite careers, one lesson: America rewards a Frenchman who gives it a tune.

PART 2

THE CIRCLE WIDENS

*Francis Lai, Georges Delerue, Gabriel Yared —
and the French Touch Before Its Name*





Francis Lai — Love in Two Chords

Nice, 1932 — Paris, 2018

Un homme et une femme, 1966. Claude Lelouch's film and Lai's "chabadabada" win the Palme d'Or and two Oscars, and make the accordionist from Nice a name.

Love Story, 1970. A theme written on the piano in Paris for a Harvard love story becomes the biggest-selling film score of its era. Oscar, 1971.

The method. Simplicity. Lai played by ear, could not read music fluently, and trusted the melody above everything.

Where others wrote symphonies, Lai wrote a line you could whistle — and the Academy whistled back.

Georges Delerue — The New Wave Goes West

Roubaix, 1925 — Los Angeles, 1992

Truffaut's composer.

Jules et Jim, Shoot the Pianist, Day for Night, The Last Metro. Godard's Contempt.



A Little Romance, 1979.

His Oscar — for a small American film — persuades him to move to Los Angeles. Platoon, Steel Magnolias, Beaches follow.

The man who scored Contempt ended his life writing for Hollywood. The New Wave followed him there.



Gabriel Yared and the Lyrical Line

Beirut, 1949 — a French Composer by Choice

Paris by way of Beirut. Lebanese-born, trained in Paris, a Godard collaborator (*Sauve qui peut* (la vie)), then *Betty Blue* (1986) — the score a generation fell in love to. **The English Patient, 1996.** Anthony Minghella's desert epic. Oscar, BAFTA, Golden Globe. **What it proves.** The "French accent" is not a passport. It is a school: melody, restraint, and a refusal to over-score the picture.

Yared is the proof that the French touch is a training, not a birthplace.

The Artist, 2011

A Silent Film That Spoke Through Music

A silent film

Black and white, 2011,
Michel Hazanavicius



Ludovic Bource

Ninety minutes of score,
no spoken dialogue



Hollywood's own myth

1920s Los Angeles, told by
Frenchmen



Best Picture

Oscars 2012, plus Best
Original Score

The French did not just write Hollywood's music. They wrote a love letter to Hollywood and won with it.

PART 3

THE FRENCH TOUCH TODAY

*Alexandre Desplat and the Sound of
Contemporary Cinema*



Alexandre Desplat — The Heir

Paris, 1961 — Eleven Oscar Nominations

The apprenticeship.

A French father, a Greek mother, a flute, and a hundred French films before Hollywood notices him with *Girl with a Pearl Earring* (2003).

The range.

The Queen, *The Curious Case of Benjamin Button*, *The King's Speech*, *Argo*, *Harry Potter*, *Godzilla*, *Little Women* — and every Wes Anderson film since *Fantastic Mr. Fox*.

The two Oscars.

The Grand Budapest Hotel (2014): balalaikas and cimbaloms. *The Shape of Water* (2017): a waltz for a mute woman and a creature.

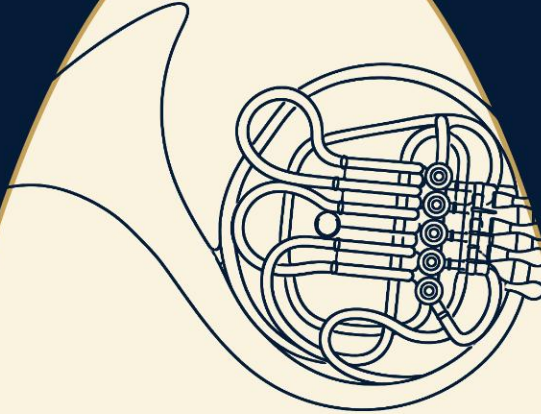
Desplat is the most nominated composer of his generation —
and the most French in his economy.





Melody First

From Lara's Theme to La Valse d'Amélie: a line you can sing. The French school was trained by Boulanger and Messiaen and never forgot the tune.



Melancholy Allowed

American scores push triumph. French composers are permitted sadness, irony and restraint — and American directors hire them for exactly that.



Elegance over Spectacle

Chamber textures, unusual instruments, silence used as music. Less is the French signature — and the Academy, every few years, rewards it.

Hollywood does not buy French music. It buys a French way of listening.

A Music with No Face

Jarre · Legrand · Lai · Delerue

Four Frenchmen whose melodies
every American can hum.

Yared · Bource · Desplat

Three more, from Beirut, Paris and
Paris.

SEVEN

1962 → 2018

Sixty years of French film music in Hollywood, and almost no American could pick one
face out of a crowd.

The most invisible French export of the century is also the one you have heard most often.

Sixty Years in One Hour

A percussionist from Lyon wrote the sound of the desert in six weeks and took three Oscars for David Lean.

A jazzman from Paris made every line of a film sing and taught Hollywood the windmills of its own mind.

An accordionist, a New Wave composer and a Beiruti pupil of the French school each took a statuette home.

And a Parisian flautist has become the most nominated composer alive — with a film about a mute woman and a waltz.



Hollywood has a French accent. It simply never asks who is speaking.

Sources & Further Reading



Reading

Michel Legrand, Rien n'est grave dans les aigus (memoir) · Stéphane Lerouge, Georges Delerue: Une vie · Mervyn Cooke, A History of Film Music · Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences, awards database.



Listening, in Order

Lawrence of Arabia (1962) · Les Parapluies de Cherbourg (1964) · Love Story (1970) · A Little Romance (1979) · The English Patient (1996) · The Grand Budapest Hotel (2014) · The Shape of Water (2017).



Watching

Doctor Zhivago (1965) · The Thomas Crown Affair (1968) · Le Mépris (1963) · The Artist (2011) · Any Wes Anderson film scored by Desplat.